DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Do All Your Misvot Count in the World to Come?

Derech Hashem 2:2:8-9

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 2, paragraphs 8-9 (end of the chapter), and the opening of Chapter 3 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 10 May 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: seats in the stadium

The Rabbi set out to finish Chapter 2. Because we have free will and the goal is a Kibbutz HaShelemim, a gathering of the perfect, our mistakes must be dealt with: some through suffering in this world, some through Gehinnom, and for some, no suffering will help, since they have no connection to the eternal. This is not arbitrary reward and punishment: the way you behave is what you choose for yourself.

The previous class ended with the point that even within the gathering of the perfect, not everyone is on the same level. "Even if you've got access into the stadium, you may be on the back seat." It is good to be there, but you may spend half the game looking at a friend sitting much nearer the pitch.

Paragraph 8: a ticket does not upgrade every misvah

The Rabbi explained the paragraph first in his own words. Suppose I have done many misvot and only a few sins, and I have atoned for those sins in this world. Should I not have a very high place in the gathering?

Not necessarily. Getting a place does not mean every good thing you have done now upgrades your seat. Some misvot may not have been done for the right motives. They are "Olam HaZeh misvot": real misvot that cannot go unnoticed, but which are rewarded in this world.

You gave a large sum to sedakah and received a big plaque with your name on it. That could be a huge misvah that raises you in the World to Come, or it could be for your own personal gain, in which case it is rewarded here, with more money or other good things. "So don't think that all the misvot which you do, once you get the pass, that everything's going to be rewarded." It works both ways: just as one pure misvah gets you in, getting in does not mean every misvah counts there. There is a constant weighing.

Can we know our own motives? Not precisely. "You need to be a psychologist for this." Many people go to shul on Shabbat morning not to pray but because it is social, and have never thought about why they go. A participant noted that we are the best psychologists of ourselves; the Rabbi agreed, but added that we also have subconscious motives that

sometimes others can see better than we can. You can say "I felt this was the right path" or "I did this just because I had to," but you cannot put a percentage on it.

Matching campaigns and peer pressure

He gave a contemporary example: online matching charity campaigns. Why are they so successful? Often not because people believe in the cause, but because a friend asks and refusing would insult him. "Half of that money which comes in is peer pressure... I've heard this countless times from people." The same was true of the big fundraising dinners, where people donated thousands in front of others.

A participant added that one who gives in to peer pressure fails to grow to the level Hashem intended. The Rabbi agreed: doing something because of peer pressure means you have not truly chosen it. It is a good deed, but an Olam HaZeh misvah.

Another participant pointed to people who do kindness for everyone but neglect their own home. "That's the test," said the Rabbi: what about the hesed you do for your wife and children?

The Ramhal's words

Based on this root, the Ramhal says there are great differences in which deeds are repaid, where, and how much. There are deeds that, under precise judgment, will not raise a person in the World to Come but will be rewarded in this world, so that he ends up "right at the back of the stadium," even though he did so much.

This resembles the reshaim discussed earlier, who received their reward in this world and were lost in the World to Come, but there is a big difference. Those reshaim's good deeds are fully repaid here and they get no eternity at all. These people did some deeds that brought them into eternity: they have a ticket and a portion, even if they need much refinement. The Rabbi noted that the Ramhal is speaking here of people who do many misvot, not of the mediocre. If their misvot had been for the right purposes they would be among the highest; because they are Olam HaZeh misvot, many are repaid here.

Do not judge by quantity

"So don't judge a person by how much he does." Of two people, one may learn more hours, but how is he using that time and for what motives? "You can't judge by quantity. It's about quality."

A participant reasoned that good people who struggle must be doing misvot for the right reasons, while a comfortable person may be at the back. The Rabbi cautioned against such conclusions. Perhaps everything the comfortable person does is perfect; perhaps one misvah earned him his place and one percent of it pays for his whole comfortable life. "Don't test this on cases." There are too many variables: his level of choice, his motives. "All we can give is principles," and only Hashem can apply them.

The Rabbi lamented that we live in a warped world that judges everything externally, a person's religiosity by what he does and "even less what he does, what he dresses." He recalled

the Gemara in Bava Batra about one who glimpsed the next world and saw "a world upside down," and the prophet Yeshayahu: "My thoughts are not your thoughts."

Paragraph 9: one answer so far

The Ramhal says that what we have learned gives one explanation for why the righteous suffer and the wicked prosper, and also explains the spiritual punishments that prepare a person for the World to Come. The righteous suffer to cleanse their bit of bad; the wicked prosper so that their bit of good is repaid.

But a participant had asked: if I am a saddik with nothing to cleanse, why am I prospering? And why are some people simply born into wealth? The Rabbi said the next chapter, perhaps the longest in the book, will address this. It will offer four or five more explanations of why the righteous suffer and the wicked prosper, and he asked everyone to keep the question in mind and point out each time something in the chapter answers it.

The chapter will also discuss what might seem a Christian idea but is not: a person atoning for his generation. It will discuss gilgulim, and the way we are all bound up with one another. And it begins with why people are born into a certain situation: some are raised with everything, some with nothing, through no choice of their own, and that upbringing shapes the first decades of life. "How is this fair?"

The opening of Chapter 3

Chapter 3 begins by recalling that our work in this world is to choose good over bad, and that there are many individual kinds of good and bad, since each character trait has its source. But it is not always simple. Humility is good, yet the Gemara in Sotah says a Torah scholar needs "an eighth of an eighth" of pride, to stand up for the Torah and for himself. Mercy is good and cruelty bad, yet being too merciful on your children is cruel, and sometimes firmness is right. The Rabbi said this would continue on Thursday.

Summary

- Even within the World to Come there are levels, like seats in a stadium.
- Getting a place does not mean every misvah raises you; misvot done for worldly motives are repaid in this world.
- Peer pressure giving, honour-seeking and kindness that neglects one's own home are examples of such "Olam HaZeh misvot."
- We cannot judge others by how much they do or how they dress; it is about quality and motive, which only Hashem knows.
- Chapter 3 will offer further answers to why the righteous suffer and the wicked prosper.

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